CARMA
CENTER FOR AI RISK MANAGEMENT & ALIGNMENT

To: [redacted]

From: The Center for AI Risk Management and Alignment

Subject: AI Action Plan RFI Submission

The Center for AI Risk Management & Alignment (CARMA) is a research and policy think tank dedicated to more securely and safely mapping the progression and effects of emergent abilities in artificial intelligence. Through progressing the sciences of AI risk and creating frameworks for AI management, we work toward unlocking more of AI's benefits for Americans.

In order to achieve the AI Action Plan's stated goal, to maintain U.S. leadership in AI, and for the nation to properly reap the benefits of technological innovation while minimizing unwanted types of disruptions to civil life and security, CARMA proposes that the AI Action Plan include a strategy for the US national security apparatus to update and enhance its orientation toward emerging technology risks with national security consequences.

The federal government has developed a variety of tools to understand AI capabilities for innovation and risk. However, given the nascent nature of AI governance, the AI research community, governments, and developers have indicated potential negative side effects for the rapid development and proliferation of AI systems.[1] As the administration seeks to develop its own governance priorities, we advocate for the below policy recommendations within the current regulatory landscape:

Recommendation 1: Monitoring and Engagement

A. Ensure that NSA, DHS, Commerce, and relevant agencies are tracking AGI developments and potential threats that stem from their proliferation. The government should continue to engage with AI developers to share information on novel threats with immediate and distant timeframes.

[1] "Governing AI for Humanity", United Nations, Sept. 2024. https://news.un.org/en/story/2024/09/1154541

B. CISA' s Joint Cyber Defense Collaborative, NIST, OSTP, and NSA all have separate engagement remits with industry- the AI Action Plan should illustrate these Lines of Effort as appropriate as a part of a larger framework for understanding AI dual use capabilities.
C. The White House should convene industry leaders and civil society groups to discuss maintaining AI leadership through prioritizing governance, security, and investment.

Recommendation 2: Assess AI technology for Risk

A. Ensure the AI Safety Institute's Testing Risks of AI for National Security Task Force is properly resourced and authorized to study the national security risks of AI models across all relevant domains. Specifically, how AI non-programmed behavior, including deceptive scheming, self-preservation, self-replication, and recursive self-improvement could lead to national security risks. The findings of the task force should regularly update the National Security Council and relevant national security agencies to inform response planning and regulatory efforts.
B. Engage with industry and civil society to develop national security Risk Assessments specifically focused on general-purpose AI systems.
C. Direct agencies within the federal research community (DARPA, NIST, OSTP, and the National Laboratories) to develop a historical report on the development of innovative technology and emergent national security risks.

Recommendation 3: Risk Reduction and Response

A. The nature of AI threats are varied and can come in a multitude of vectors, resulting in a threat environment that will prove difficult to respond to without properly prepared emergency response mechanisms. Therefore, we recommend that the federal government establish a framework for emergency preparedness to respond to and deter AI-related threats of national significance. This framework should include:

   - Threat monitoring within the intelligence community and homeland security enterprises. Relevant agencies should ensure that cyber vulnerabilities databases are updated with relevant threat vector information as novel AI threats arise.
   - Red team and table top exercises with teams of emergency response and germane Sector Risk Management Agencies (e.g. CISA, FEMA , HHS, and a relevant Intelligence Community partner for health-related AI threats) for knowledge management and response plan development.

- Early warning detection mechanisms
- Communications and coordination plans. Presidential Policy Directive 41, the National Cyber Incident Response Plan and other relevant national security documents have established coordinating mechanisms that centralize command, control and communication for cyber emergencies - these structures should be tested and updated as appropriate for the types of threats that experts think plausible from advanced general-purpose agentic AI.
- FEMA, in its 2050 Strategic Foresight Report, recognized that developments in AI could lead to emergent behaviors that are hard to predict or interpret. AI-enhanced bad actors may also introduce chemical or geoengineering threats to public health. Cyberattacks involving AI that could interrupt critical government functions or sow mistrust of the government present significant national security risk to the emergency preparedness function. FEMA, as the federal emergency response agency, should play an integral role in developing response plans from AI threats.
- The White House, State, CISA, NIST and the IC should engage in international efforts for minimizing risk from nation state actors, transnational AI threats to US critical infrastructure. These multilateral efforts should include engaging with allies to share information and coordinate response planning as appropriate, and lead on AI governance in multilateral fora including NATO, the UN, and the G7.
- The Plan should instruct the Bureau of Industry and Security to mandate that companies develop and install geolocation and geofencing capabilities so that AI chips, and their systems, are used in pre-approved areas and do not fall into the hands of malevolent foreign actors. As a failsafe, BIS should assess the feasibility of mandating targeted deactivation capabilities within powerful AI chips as the national security landscape evolves to necessitate the action.
- The White House should implement distinct yet coordinated bioassessment (monitoring and detection) and bioremediation (mitigation and response) capabilities to respond to novel AI/bio threats:
    a. Bioassessment**:** Designate a responsible entity, such as the Biosecurity, Assessments, and Materials group within Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory's Physical and Life Sciences Directorate, to develop advanced methods for

detecting and characterizing AI-enhanced bio-threats. This designation should be accompanied by an institutional gap analysis to determine required capabilities and funding.

b. Bioremediation**:** Clearly define coordination mechanisms among emergency response agencies, including the Department of Homeland Security (DHS), Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), and relevant state and local entities, ensuring rapid containment, mitigation, and public communication in response to detected threats.

The White House should also establish formal collaboration mechanisms between government, private sector biotechnology firms, academic research institutions, and international partners to facilitate information sharing, joint preparedness exercises, and timely response to novel AI bio threats.

Conclusion

The above recommendations outline a multi-layered governmental approach to tracking, assessing, and mitigating potential AI-driven national security risks. The framework emphasizes proactive monitoring through interagency and external collaboration, rigorous technological risk assessment, and establishing robust emergency response preparedness. The policy proposals advocate for a flexible, anticipatory governance structure that can rapidly adapt to the complex and evolving landscape of AI-related national security challenges while maintaining AI leadership in the global landscape.